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Special Report

"MAGNETIC MARKETING" OF SEMINARS, CONFERENCES AND CONVENTIONS

48 Big Ideas For Dramatically Increasing Attendance At Any Meeting Or Event

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"MAGNETIC MARKETING" OF SEMINARS, CONFERENCES AND CONVENTIONS

After just a few brief paragraphs of introduction, we'll roll up our sleeves and get to work....and, I promise you, we'll unearth strategies you'll be excited about using, to boost attendance at your next event.

Who Is Behind This Report - And - "Why should I listen to you?"

My name is Dan Kennedy. I am, first, a direct-response advertising and direct marketing professional, routinely commanding upwards from $800.00 per hour for my advice. Second, I'm a professional speaker; I address about 200,000 people a year and this is my 20th year of delivering 30 to 70 compensated presentations each and every year. Third, I started, built (and sold) a large, specialty seminar company; I promote my own Conferences, at $2,000.00 to $5,000.00 per person, very successfully; and I do a lot of work in seminar marketing.

If you'd like to know more about me, please visit www.dankennedy.com or request information from my office via FAX @ 602-269-3113.

I belabor all this a bit, just so that you feel good about the advice, ideas and information that I've assembled for you in this Report.

Now, let's get started with the "48 ideas".....

How Your Speaker(s) Can And Should Help You Attract The Maximum Possible Response To Your Seminar, Conference Or Event

I'm often surprised at the number (majority) of my speaking colleagues who do little more than show up, deliver a speech, pocket their check and leave. And I'm equally surprised by the number of clients who seem to be perfectly okay with that.

There ought to be more!

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IDEA #1

Collect From The Speaker Powerful, Proven Promotional Copy And Testimonials For Use In YOUR Brochures, Sales Letters & Other Promotional Material

Why should you have to create all this from scratch? Why re-invent the wheel? The speaker should be able to provide you with proven, powerful advertising copy he and his clients have used to successfully promote himself, his presentations and his products. (If he can't, there might be something wrong!)

For example, I provide tested and proven brochure or sales letter copy and "bullet points" about my presentations, testimonials from clients and audience members, reprintable articles, and I frequently customize this for a client, as well as providing a series of pre-event e-mails that can be sent by the client to its members or employees. All of this is designed to help the client use me as a "Shamu The Whale" attraction. You should get this kind of a "leg up" from every speaker you work with.

IDEA #2

Have The Speaker Work With You, To Create Innovative Marketing Strategies And Customized Marketing Tools

Maybe you and the speaker can work together, to create unique marketing tools. For example, I created a "Special Report" just for the New Mexico Realtors Association to advertise and use to promote my speech at their convention. I've included a copy of that Report in APPENDIX-A of this Report. In this case, the Association ran what I call "lead generation ads" in their own newsletters, to get people to request this Report, then sent out the Report, as a means of advance-promoting their convention.

(This is a very powerful strategy because people pay more attention to a "Report" that they have asked for than to anything sent to them unsolicited. You responded to this same strategy - that's how this Report landed in your hands. This System: getting a qualified person to request a Report, delivering the Report, and letting the Report present your offer will often "close" from 30% to 50% of the respondents.)

What can a speaker custom-create for you? Well, a "Special Report" like the example in APPENDIX-A is a very good idea. But here are a few more:

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IDEA #3
A Special Audio Tape

You could interview your speaker (over the phone), ask him questions that will be of interest to your members....include "snippets" of the speaker's "live" recorded speeches....even interview a couple testimonials....and create a very listenable, very exciting audio "Preview" to be sent out to your prospective attendees. This can be very inexpensive. It's easy for the speaker to do this for you. And it can be very powerful.

IDEA #4
A Special "Free Recorded Message"

Similar to the Audio Tape: the speaker can record a 3 to 10-minute-or-so message, interview, etc. as a recorded message accessible by phone. You can then use a regular phone number (if you want your prospective attendees to pay the long-distance cost of the call) or an 800-number (if you want to pay the costs), publish and promote that number, and let your prospective attendees dial up at their convenience and hear the "Preview."

(Did you know that adding a "free recorded message" offer like this to advertisements or mailings can often generate calls from 50%+ of all the recipients?....and frequently as much as QUADRUPLES response to the main offer?")

With today's voice-mail technology, this is all very, very easy to do. There are many service bureaus you can use. In many cities, the local "Bell" phone company is in this business.

And, as an option, you can have automatic name/address capture, so you know who has called (and who hasn't), and can direct different followup mailings to those who have vs. those who haven't.

IDEA #5
Special Video Presentations

Many organizations prepare and send out a promotional video for their conventions and conferences. Most major hotels, resorts and conference centers can and will furnish video footage of their facilities that you can add to such a video. The speaker should also happily give you a "dub-master" of his demo-video or other video products for you to integrate into your video.

Some speakers may also be able to give you some good testimonials of theirs on video that you can integrate into your video.

By the way, if you're not familiar with the production or duplication of such videos, I can help. For example, in quantities of hundreds, you can get your video duplication costs down to $1.00 to $2.50. In big quantities, there are even "disposable videos", with the shell made of fiberboard instead of plastic, that cost less than a dollar.

Why not get your speaker involved in creating dynamic promotional tools?

IDEA #6
Can Your Speaker Provide Exciting Literature "AT COST"?

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Maybe the speaker has a brochure or some other piece of literature already done, produced in sizeable quantity, and sitting on his shelf, that he can let you have at his cost....a lot less than you could duplicate it from scratch....and have it ready to use instantly. For example, we have a "newspaper page" tear sheet all about me, which costs only pennies each, that many clients like to buy in bulk at our cost, and use.

IDEA #7
Your Speaker Can Write For Your Newsletter, For Months Before Your Event.

Most good speakers are pretty good writers. Many author books (I have 8 in bookstores). Many speakers publish their own newsletters. (I do.) So it's a very easy task for a speaker to write and provide you with a series of articles, tailored to your business, for you to publish in your newsletter. This helps your prospective attendees gain respect for the speaker and develop interest in what the speaker has to offer.

At the very least, if the speaker's schedule prohibits meeting your deadlines for custom articles, he should provide some articles, books and newsletters that you can publish excerpts of.

IDEA #8
Optional Services The Speaker Might Provide, To Build Interest

In some cases, the speaker might survey or interview some or all of your prospective attendees, and incorporate the results of that in his presentation. For example, several years ago, for an association of agricultural consultants, I conducted 15-minute telephone interviews with their ten most successful consultants, and used that information in my presentation. And the fact that I was gathering this information and would be revealing it was heavily promoted. This created considerable curiosity. Everybody was eager to know what these people would tell me in complete confidence.

In another case, I masqueraded as a "prospect", went to five company sites, had their salespeople make presentations to me, then, in the pre-conference promotion, my "shopping" was revealed, and the fact that I would be including my report in my presentation was heavily promoted.

Obviously, there are extra costs involved in such pre-event activities, but the cost is often more than recovered through additional registrations.

The speaker can also give you extra promotional ammunition by agreeing to participate in a "VIP Reception" for certain attendees....to be available at a "roundtable" for "semi-private" consultations with your attendees after his speech....and so on.

Special "Promotional Power Tools" Your Speaker May be Able to Put Into Your Hands

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What is a "Promotional Power Tool"? It is something that gives you a very big edge, that is incredibly magnetic, that simply makes people eager to come and hear your speaker.

When you construct the MARKETING MESSAGE about the speaker(s) you are featuring at your event, here are the special Promotional Power Tools you should look for, from the speaker:

IDEA #9
Exceptional Credibility

These days, people do not want "ideas." I tell my audiences that the speaking circuit is chock full of people who sell only in their memories, run businesses only in their nightmares, and run around telling audiences how to do what they don't do. Do you think your audience really wants to be "lab rats"? Of course not. So, real credibility is very important. YOU have to be able to make very strong, positive, specific (and true!) statements about the speaker's expertise, experience and activities that will convince your prospective attendees that this is a person they are certain to profit by hearing.

For example, the fact that, "hands-on, in his consulting work, Dan Kennedy has successfully applied the strategies featured in his presentation in 136 different businesses, industries and professions in the last several years alone" - helps make the point that these strategies are universally applicable.

A speaker who has professionally produced valuable products gains credibility, too. More about this later.

IDEA #10
Exciting CELEBRITY

No, I'm not necessarily talking about *People Magazine*-type celebrities - we'll talk about those later. I am talking about the "quality of celebrity." There's no doubt about it, celebrity *is* magnetic. People want to get up close and personal with people who have this quality. A speaker helps you tremendously when he makes it possible for you to position him as a celebrity. Here are some of the ways this can be done:

1) A speaker who is a legitimately published author, with one or more books on bookstore shelves, reviewed by major magazines, and endorsed by well-known people, can be positioned as a celebrity. Most people still look up to and are intrigued by authors. Often, a lot of the publicity and promotion that has been created for the speaker's book can be easily adapted for your needs.

2) A speaker who is somehow "media oriented" can be positioned as a celebrity. Obviously, if your speaker has appeared on *Oprah* or *Donahue* or the others, or on the *Today Show,* or the *Tonight Show,* etc., that can be used. My speaking colleague, Lee Milteer, for example, appeared regularly for two years on *The Dini Petty Show,* the #1 rated daytime TV talk show in Canada, and has appeared on *Sally Jesse Raphael* and *Montel,* and this helps make her promoteable as a celebrity.

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3) A speaker who frequently appears on programs with "big name" celebrities has that "stardust" rub off, and that can be used to position him as a celebrity. My speaking colleagues Zig Ziglar, Tom Hopkins, Jim Rohn, Peter Lowe, and I, get to frequently appear with people like General Norman Schwarzkopf, former President Bush, General Colin Powell, Coach Lou Holtz, Olympian Mary Lou Retton, broadcasters Larry King and Paul Harvey, Reverend Robert Schuller, and many others, and that goes a long way in positioning somebody like me as a celebrity.

A speaker who frequently addresses large audiences also has "star quality" as a result. I find that people are fascinated by the fact that I often speak to audiences of 10,000 to 25,000.

IDEA #11
The PREDICTIVE Personality

You undoubtedly know who Jeanne Dixon is. You probably know who Faith Popcorn and John Naisbitt are. Why are these people known? Because they make predictions, and people are fascinated by forecasts of the future. Think about how much radio and TV time and newspaper space is consumed speculating about what will happen in the future. Who will emerge as the #1 Presidential contender? Who will falter? Yes, everywhere you turn, people have "inquiring minds" about what WILL happen.

When a speaker can link his information and presentations to cutting edge trends, to preparing people for the "secrets" waiting just around the corner, he becomes more promoteable.

IDEA #12
The PROVOCATIVE Personality

Rarely do you want a speaker who is so controversial as to be disliked by a significant number of your prospective attendees. You want to steer clear of "loose cannons" and "lightning rods." You do not want controversy just for the sake of controversy.

On the other hand, it's hard to get people excited about somebody who doesn't stand for anything. So you might think of it this way: you may not want a controversial speaker, but you probably want a provocative personality.

For example, Sydney Biddle Barrows, the infamous "Mayflower Madam" tried launching a speaking career, holding herself out as an authority on "customer service." (Honest. No joke. Really.) But even if you took her seriously --- and it so happens she is an intelligent, articulate person who probably has some very useful ideas --- hiring her would be "controversial." Think of everybody you might instantly offend. Women. The devoutly religious. And so on.

As another example: for a number of years, there was a speaker who worked in the insurance industry who used this "headline" to promote himself: Who Is This 'Expert' And Why Is He Saying So Many Terrible Things About The Way We Sell Insurance? That was provocative alright, but not unmanageably controversial. And it helped him enjoy a very successful speaking career. When he did "break-out sessions", his were Standing Room Only while others were half-empty.

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Several years ago, I used the title "Fire Your Advertising Agency" as a speech title for certain business organizations, and they found that a record number of company owners and CEO's came to those meetings.

How You Can Increase EARLY Registration

As you might guess, getting members of the International Procrastinators Association to register early for their convention is a real challenge. But that poor meeting planner is not alone.

Certainly one of the most frustrating aspects of planning and promoting meetings has to be the number of people who wait and wait and wait to register. Here is my little Checklist of "Early Registration Boosters." You undoubtedly know of and use some of these already. But maybe there's a trick or two here you haven't tried yet. They all have impact.

IDEA #13
Give Away The Speaker's Book, A Tape Or A Special Report

People love to get autographed books. Often, you can buy a speaker's book, from him or from his publisher, at a 40%, 50% or even better discount. You might give a free autographed book to the early-bird registrants.....or give the book AND a special "closed door" autograph session with the speaker only to the early-bird registrants.

Or you might work with your speaker to have him create a Special Report or special Audio Tape with a sizzling hot title, that everybody will want - but that will be available only to early-bird registrants.

IDEA #14
Staggered Price Increases

This is quite common in seminar marketing: X$ if you register by A-date, (a higher) Y$ if you register after A but by B-date, and a (still higher) Z$ if you register after B-date.

This sometimes works even better if tied to bonuses and premiums, so that you get the lowest price plus 3 bonuses if you register by A, a higher price and only two bonuses @ B, the highest price and only one bonus @ C; a higher-than-highest price and no bonus at the door. This mixes punishment for late registration with reward for early registration.

IDEA #15
Early Bird Discount

I suppose this is the most commonly used strategy of all and, although it's "old hat", it still works.

If you mail out your registration materials in an envelope, then this works best if presented in a separate coupon or certificate - NOT included in the "regular" brochure and sign-

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up form. Or you can incorporate the Early Bird Discount offer in a "Read This Only If You're Still Undecided" note inside a sealed envelope.

A variation of this that drives people to call to register is giving the Early Bird Discount only to "the first ____ # of attendees." Used cleverly, this can create a "the race is on" stampede of very fast response.

IDEA #16
Easy Payments

One obstacle to early registrations is the people having to pay for the event 6 weeks, 8 weeks or more in advance. A very effective counter to this is accepting payments. This is especially easy if your people are registering using a major credit card. Your copy might read something like this:

> **"Now you can register early - and get all the Early Bird Benefits -- but you do NOT have to pay early!** We'll charge just $100.00 of your $300.00 registration fee to your credit card now, when you call or FAX back this Form....the next $100.00 only twenty-five days before the Conference....and the final $100.00 just 3 days before the Conference. Register now, pay painlessly!"

IDEA #17
Early Bird Bonus Gifts

Everybody loves bonus gifts! My clients in the newsletter industry, for example, routinely use bonus gifts to "drive the sale." (For example, take a look at all the bonuses that new subscribers to my newsletter get - www.dankennedy.com.)

Depending on your type of conference, you might consider imprinted baseball caps, T-shirts, polo shirts, portfolios or duffel bags with the company or association logo and conference logo or slogan....information products, like books.....coffee mugs....let your imagination loose! *(ADVERTISING AGE MAGAZINE* runs a very, very, very successful promotion to acquire new subscribers, where each new subscriber gets a coffee mug with a simulation of the front page of a newspaper, with a headline with the subscriber's name in it - it says "Subscriber Name Awarded Advertising Genius Of The Year".)

IDEA #18
Prize Drawing For Early Birds Only

Most associations can get their vendors and exhibitors to ante up desirable prizes for an exciting prize drawing. However, if you need to find all sorts of great prizes (like all those "As Seen On TV" products, appliances, electronics, jewelry, etc.) at below-wholesale, incredibly low

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costs, you need to know about the "Promotional Merchandise And Close-Out Industry." I've written a how-to Manual for my clients, customers and subscribers. If you'd like a copy, it's available.

IDEA #19
Early Bird VIP Privileges

The famous Blanchard financial conferences use Preferred Seating, Special "Closed Door" Breakfasts and Receptions, and "Closed Door" Meet-The-Speaker Sessions as VIP Privileges to boost early registration.

Advertising & Marketing Message Secrets That Can Dramatically Boost Response To Your Sales Letters, Brochures, Mailings, Ads In Newsletters, Etc.

I need to back up for just a minute - back to a bit more introduction of me. A large part of my consulting practice involves direct-response copywriting. Odds are, this week, you've read a full-page magazine ad I've written for a client or read a direct-mail package I've created for a client or watched a TV infomercial I worked on. I routinely command $15,000.00 and up (plus royalties) to write an ad or direct-mail package, and 70% of my business is repeat/continuing. Quite bluntly and immodestly, I know as much or more about creating "Killer Copy" as anybody on the planet. And my friends include several more top, highest-paid pro copywriters - and it's a small fraternity. Anyway, keep all that in mind as you consider this information about adding "high impact" to your promotional materials....

IDEA #20
Compelling Headlines

Here's something very few people understand: 80% of the success or failure of an ad, letter or brochure depends on its headline(s).

My friend and colleague, Ted Nicholas, who has sold over 200-million dollars worth of his business books via full-page ads in *The Wall Street Journal,* business magazines, and by direct-mail, often writes over 100 different headlines before choosing the best one for an ad or a sales letter. (I'm going to shortcut that for YOU.)

What you NEVER want to do is use dull, textbook-y headlines like "Seminar Agenda"...."List Of Speakers"...."Registration Information." Ugh. Ugh. Ugh.

Here are a few quick tips:

* Each Headline should telegraph a positive benefit

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* Each Headline should be an "ad" for the copy below, that you want the person to read

* When possible, a Headline should arouse curiosity

* "How To" is a "power phrase" for Headlines

* "Secrets" is a "power word" for Headlines

So, for example, instead of "List Of Speakers" as a Headline we might use something like this:

9 World-Class Speaking Superstars
Reveal Their Most Profitable & Powerful
Sales, Marketing, Management
& Success Secrets To You

Incidentally, many Headlines benefit from having longer Sub-Heads underneath them, in smaller type. And Sub-Heads work just like Headlines....like this:

9 World-Class Speaking Superstars
Reveal Their Most Profitable & Powerful
Sales, Marketing, Management
& Success Secrets To You

For Our 1999 "Marketplace Dominator Conference", We've Scoured The Earth To Find THE Nine Speakers Best Qualified And Absolutely Certain To Send You Home "Armed And Dangerous", Equipped With New Competitive Weaponry So Powerful It Should Have A 10-Day Waiting Period Required By Law!

Now, how can you "short-cut" the process of creating your own super-powerful headlines? For starters, there is a book called "How To Write A Good Advertisement" by Victor Schwab, available at many libraries, bookstores or from my office - this book includes "the 100 most successful headlines ever written." They are all formulaic. Here's what I mean: a very famous, successful headline was:

"Who Else Wants A Screen Star Figure:"

Made into a fill-in-the blank formula:

"Who Else Wants _____?"

For example:

* Who Else Wants A $100,000.00 A Year Income In The Carpet Cleaning Business?

* Who Else Wants To Find And Hire "Super Employees"?

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* Who Else Wants To Know The Newest Million-Dollar Roundtable's 5 Most Prized Persuasion Secrets?

IDEA #21
"Bullet Points"

"Bullet Points" are extremely important. You've all seen them - these are "one-liners" with "bullets" in front of them. Now here's the two big secrets to creating great bullet points: (1) be sure to get to BENEFITS (not just FEATURES) .....and (2) write each bullet point exactly as you would a headline.

For more information, take a look at the article from one of the Issues of my marketing newsletter about bullet points that follows:

HOW TO CREATE DIRECT-MAIL PACKAGES THAT GET OPENED AND READ

"A-Pile Mail" is not the only way to go. YOU HOPEFULLY STUDY *"BOARDROOM REPORTS"* DIRECT-MAIL....the #10 envelopes covered, I mean COVERED with teaser copy - like: What Never To Eat On An Airplane, page 17....What Your Banker Prays You'll Never Find Out, page 38....etc. The sales letters used by *Boardroom* to sell their newsletters and books rely heavily, and very, very successfully on this single approach - the idea of someone not wanting you to know something...of a conspiracy keeping secrets from you. The creator of all this for *Boardroom,* Mel Martin, died in February, at age 70. During his copywriting career, over 100-Million envelopes and letters went out with his copy on them. Here are some of the tantalizing, provocative bullet points from *Boardroom's* current, Mel Martin "control" (promoting their *Bottom Line Newsletter*):

- Cruise ship rapes: the uncensored facts which even the news media won't touch.
- The little-known casinos that offer the best odds.
- Get a hotel suite...while paying for a room!
- This letter is about information that's "none of your business".
- Conventional wisdom: you can't push an insurance company when it comes to collecting money. Wrong! There are two proven ways to get your check within days.
- How to outwit a mugger in a self-service elevator. (One of the worst big city traps.)
- How to spot an honest auto mechanic.

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1 Eight things to leave out of a job resume.

IDEA #22
"Salesmanship In Print"

Many brochures are "addy" and institutional....and I can beat them with half my brain tied behind my back, with simple sales letters - with the key being that they do *not* sound "addy" or institutional at all. The trick is to write person-to-person, not institution-to-people. And to write "jus' like ya talk."

I urge you to get and read a copy of my book THE ULTIMATE SALES LETTER. You can get it at bookstores - most Barnes & Noble stores included, at most Kinkos stores or from amazon.com. This book takes you through a 28-step sales letter writing system and helps you write in a persuasive voice. And, even if you think you can't write a grocery list, you CAN do this, with this book as your coach. (Would you like to see a letter written this way, aimed at high-level executives in a particular industry, that pulled a double-digit response and put 42 people in a new conference at $1,500.00 each? One of my clients wrote it. I'll get you a copy at your request.)

IDEA #23
"SLICK" Is Rarely Best

"What!?! - you don't just LOVE my six-color, die-cut, coated stock, super expensive, glamorous, award-winning brochure?"

Maybe you know the name Anver Suleiman. He is a "guru" of seminar marketing. He once took a beautiful, full-color, "slick" brochure and turned it into what he called an "El Dullo" ....exact same words, but in ordinary typewriter type, black-and-white, dull, simple. He tested the two pieces against one another, in a tightly controlled situation. El Dullo beat Beautiful 5-to-1.

It is because of Anver's discoveries that one of the largest seminar companies in America frequently relied on "El Dullo" black and gray on white 8 and 16-page letters or "Reports" to fill their seminars, even though they had very "deep pockets" and could easily have gone with much snazzier, more costly literature.

Is this ALWAYS true? No. In fact, THE best strategy is to use El Dullo pieces in tandem with Beautiful pieces, to mix Sales Letters with Brochures. Different people respond best to different approaches.

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IDEA #24

A SERIES Of Timed, Linked Mailings, NEVER JUST ONE

One of the most effective Magnetic Marketing Systems that I teach to most of my audiences, customers, subscribers and clients is the "3-Step Letter System". I do not have space here to go through it all. But I can tell you that "one shot" mailings have all the odds against them. Instead, a series of mailings, each linked to the prior one, roughly ten to no more than twenty days apart - such a series will often provide very dramatic results. As you might know, overall, ordinary, "average" direct-mail results range from 1/4th-of-1% to 2%, rarely more than 5%....but my multi-letter Systems routinely deliver response rates of 15%, 30% even 50% and more!

What Kinds Of Speakers Attract The Best Attendance? -- Insiders, Outsiders, Celebrities, Motivators, Humorists - What?

I'm afraid there's no one good answer to this, which is why many programs are built with a "mix" of different kinds of speakers. But I have some thoughts that may be helpful to you.

IDEA #25

Insiders vs. Outsiders

Many organizations rely heavily on "insiders", such as their own top salespeople, corporate executives and vendors' representatives, for three reasons: one, cost; two, certain and perceived relevance; and three, no fear of a "gaffe." And there are very sound, understandable reasons. Personally, I think it's good to have "insiders" on a program, because of certain, very specific relevance. However, us "outsiders" can play a very important role, too.

First of all, as an obstacle for promoting the insiders: *familiarity* breeds contempt. Even though someone may be a superstar performer, doing better than everybody else, and obviously doing certain things more effectively than everybody else, his peers still resist learning from him. They just know him too well. Some are jealous. Second, insiders are often not very good on the platform. In some cases, your prospective attendees may even know that the insider is a dull speaker. So, it is often a whole lot easier to promote an outsider.

Second, outsiders can often say the same things the corporate leadership has been saying - but have it listened to, considered and responded to differently. So, savvy executives can work with an outside speaker to "carry the water" for a very important corporate message.

Third, outside speakers help people see themselves and their businesses with "fresh eyes" ....help people think more creatively, "outside the box"....and can guide people to renewed enthusiasm for their activities and opportunities.

Fourth, an outside speaker may have extraordinary expertise in a particular subject unmatched by anybody inside your own organization.

Maximum attendance is often achieved with a smart mix of insiders and outsiders.

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IDEA #26
Big-Name (Big Fee) Celebrities, Yes Or No?

Well, there is no doubt that getting to hear (and get an autographed football from) my friends Fran Tarkenton or Danny White, or play a round of golf with Arnold Palmer, or hear my speaking colleague General Schwarzkopf is very, very appealing and can be a strong "drawing card" for an event. Having such a Big Name Celebrity on your program *can* be very magnetic.

Of course, many such celebrities are shockingly expensive. And, with rare exception, there is little "content value" to be had - just drawing card value and overall attendee satisfaction value.

I would say that, given sufficient budget, putting a Big Name on your program is a real plus.

It is a huge mistake, though, if that single Big Name Speaker uses up so much of your budget that you are hamstrung when it comes to providing other values, notably content value, through other professional speakers.

I'd also suggest that you can take a very good professional speaker and, through smart promotion, elevate them to such stature as to be just as big of a drawing card as most Big-Name Celebrities.

If you do hire a Big-Name Celebrity, negotiate "tough" and get as much promotional value as you possibly can - not just the speech but a VIP Reception, autographed books, footballs, or whatever. And in your literature, tell your Star's story in full, in all its glory. Do NOT assume everybody already knows all that stuff. Tell it all. Make the absolute most of this Magnet you are paying so dearly for.

IDEA #27
"Not Another Motivational Speaker!"

How many times can you handle hearing the "there must be a pony in here somewhere!" story?

The day of the rah-rah, zip-e-de-doo-dah speaker mouthing positive platitudes, leading group cheers, and telling inspirational stories, are almost over. There are about two handfuls of these I know well, who are so very, very, very good at their performances that they stay in demand, year after year. But, for the most part, audiences just aren't attracted by this anymore. (That doesn't mean they don't NEED it, by the way.)

The attraction of neuro-linguini psychobabble seems to be waning a bit too.

So, if you ARE going to put this kind of a speaker on your program, maybe in a keynote, luncheon or awards dinner slot, I think you have to be very clever and creative about titling and describing his presentation. Hopefully, the speaker can help you here.

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IDEA #28
What About Humor?

Early in my speaking career, I asked an old pro - "do you HAVE to be funny?" Deadpan, he said, "Only if you want to be paid." Over the years, I've arrived at a personal "formula" of combining humorous, true-life stories, a few one-liners, and "sense of fun", to rarely "tell jokes." I use humor as a teaching and rapport-building tool, not as an end in itself.

There's no doubt that people prefer being entertained to being educated. That's why Jay Leno and David Letterman whip Ted Koppel almost every night. But I don't think you want to - or will attract or satisfy your audiences - with a program full of humor. Every city has a comedy club. Speakers can easily overdo this, and wind up entertaining more than they do anything else, in a misguided, Willy Lomanesque exercise in being liked.

For a luncheon or dinner, you might want a "pure" humorist, and there are a number of very good humorous speakers out there. Last year, at an "Excellence In Dentistry Conference" where I spoke about marketing, Dr. Charles Jarvis did a humorous after-dinner talk, and he is still one of the all-time best. Contemporaries Dale Irvin and Kurt Kilpatrick are both terrific. But one such presentation per conference, convention or event is enough.

IDEA #29
Feature The Speaker Who Will Put Money In Their Pockets

Attending meetings, conventions and conferences is increasingly expensive. In many industries, attendees really have to weigh the time away from their businesses and other costs carefully. For example: I spoke for members of a "buying group" - all independent owners of small appliance stores. To get these people to leave their stores for three days and invest in attending a convention takes a lot. In such instances, it's extra-important to feature a speaker who promises very specific, practical, how-to information that will directly impact on sales and profits.

But - for virtually ALL groups - I believe people are most attracted by the promise of real, measurable, dollars-and-cents improvements in their businesses or sales careers.

Get such a speaker AND do the best possible job of describing him and his presentation in this light....as someone who will send people home ready, able, eager and better equipped to increase their incomes.

IDEA #30
Always Feature The Speaker Who Proudly Offers Appropriate Take-Home Educational Materials

I hope you'll give very, very thorough and careful consideration to what I have to say about this. I think this is as important as anything I've said in this Report.

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Let's start with a generous dose of realism and honesty: any speaker who claims he can create lasting, real behavioral change or equip people with new skills they can use in one speech, well, he will lie about a lot of other things too. Or he is ego deluded.

People just canNOT hear and see, understand, consider, accept, internalize and remember new ideas, information or ways of doing things without both repetition and reference materials. What they hear one time is 50% forgotten in just 48 hours. By the time they get home from your conference, 98% of everything your speakers said is but a vague memory. Further, if they leave without materials that can provide repetition AND tools for implementation, they have pretty much wasted their time.

Actually, about all the best speaker can do in a single, short presentation is open minds, provoke new thought, present new options, and succeed at inspiring such confidence and enthusiasm for those new options that people cheerfully invest their own money and time in moving ahead to implement those ideas.

I feel that just giving a great speech or seminar without offering those who "get it" that opportunity of implementation lacks integrity.

And here's some more truth: it's actually pretty easy to manipulate laughter, applause, even a standing ovation from most audiences. It's easy to create *temporary* enthusiasm. That's all style. Any good "performer" can get that done. But it all turns into ether pretty quickly. And if you let your attendees go home, with everything they saw and heard dissolving into useless ether even as they fly or drive away, you will have a much tougher time of convincing them to attend the next time around.

A much more valid measurement of how good a job a speaker does and what kind of impact he really has is: how many members of his audience eagerly reach into their pockets and invest their money in tools to reinforce and implement what they heard.

(Many speakers avoid this harsh but 100% accurate measurement of their effectiveness - their egos can't stand that much truth. Some of these speakers become outspoken critics of on-site selling or "platform selling." Recognize these speakers for what they are: sour-grapes carrying, gutless wonders.)

I provide "tool kits" (not just books and tapes) and I provide very strong, specific guarantees. My typical "commercial" lasts less than 8 minutes. And in every case, this part of my message is very well-received. In "closed groups", over 30% to as much as 70% of the audience members accept my offer. But here's what is most important: because they take home tools they have invested in, they get those tools out and use them, they get results - and many let their companies or associations know that they have really benefited. These people go home with REAL value.

Here's a tip: make sure that the speaker gives your group a generous discount and or special bonuses with the educational materials offered, and that discount should be presented by the speaker as "arranged for your group by your President, Charlie Smith, and your Convention Chair, Virginia Jones." Also NEVER let a speaker sell materials without a clear, straightforward satisfaction guarantee.

Incidentally, most audiences perceive the speaker who has an extensive, appropriate "product line" and offers them useful products to be more credible and professional than those who lack this asset. It's worth noting that THE most famous, highest paid professional speakers of our time have comprehensive collections of "product" -- such as Ken Blanchard, Tom Peters, Tony Robbins, Zig Ziglar.

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Can "Hi-Tech" Help You Achieve Record Attendance For Your Next Event?

More and more conference-marketers are using "technology". Now, I'll confess to you in advance that I am far from being a "techie". I can turn my computer on and I travel with a laptop, but if we had guns, we'd get new computers every week. And most of the gadgets I touch instantly hemorrhage and malfunction. Still, even I can use some "tech stuff" in marketing, so can anybody else.

IDEA #31
FAX The Facts Fast!

The FAX machine is my all-time favorite piece of equipment. It's simple to operate. It's remarkably cheap. And FAX communications have impact.

For marketing, "Broadcast FAX" can be a wonderful tool. With software for your computer or using an outside service, you can instantly deliver your letter, flyer, etc. to 100, 1,000 or 10,000 people via FAX. If you have your prospective attendees' FAX numbers, you have this opportunity in your hands. And here are some of the best ways to use a FAX communiqué, to heighten interest in your event:

IDEA #32:

A few days after you've mailed out your primary package of information, send a "we made a mistake" or "we forgot" FAX. Maybe you "made a mistake" and listed the member-rate as $995.00 when it should have said $695.00....maybe "you forgot" to include info about the fantastic free bonus gift and VIP seating for the first 100 registrants. Etc.

IDEA #33:

If a news event occurs that you can use to focus attention on your event, you can send out a special FAX bulletin about that.

IDEA #34:

FAX a "FINAL NOTICE" to those who have not registered one day before the expiration of the Early Bird Discount.

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IDEA #35
How To Use FAX-ON-DEMAND To Boost Interest In Your Event

You probably know how FAX-ON-DEMAND works. If there are ten speakers at your Conference, you could put an in-depth Report or an article or series of articles by each speaker up on a F.O.D. System, then your prospective attendee can instantly obtain the one(s) that most interest him, anytime, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Because the technology itself is seductive, this gets people "involved." It also saves you money vs. the costs of sending all the information to everybody.

You might even send out just a dirt-cheap postcard, announcing the upcoming Conference, and letting those interested get the "Advance Information" via FAX-ON-DEMAND.

Or you could take the same basic approach using the Internet. If you have a web site, you can post a lot more information there (at virtually no cost) than you might want to pay to get printed and mailed. You can also use an auto-responder at your site to instantly deliver additional information by e-mail to those requesting it. You might also set up click-links from your site to each speaker's site. You could have attendees register on line and/or complete pre-event questionnaires on line, even obtain articles, reports and other "freebies" in a restricted access, password activated portion of the site only for registered attendees.

"Tricks" That Never Fail To Boost Response And Registrations

IDEA #36
Questionnaires

People are eager to have their opinions and ideas heard. Maybe you've noticed: most political fundraising mailings include questionnaires to be sent back with the donations. Why? Because the questionnaires boost response! (Oh, you thought they were really interested in your opinions. Well, maybe they are. But the #1 reason is: boost response. Believe me: I know.)

IDEA #37
Participation

I recently attended a four day convention, marketed to a universe of roughly 2,500 members. There were about 1,500 of them there. And 500 of them were on the program! -- as introducers, panelists, designated question-askers, and so on. Look for ways to increase the involvement and participation level of the event.

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IDEA #38
The "Non-Disclosure Agreement"

I personally use this a lot, to add value and intrigue. Make one of your sessions so "special", so valuable that, to attend, the person has to sign and send/FAX in a "Non-Disclosure Agreement" certifying he will use the information gained only in his own business, only in an ethical manner, and will not disseminate, distribute or disclose to others.

IDEA #39
The "Mystery Speaker"

If you have a speaker that you can describe in a way that makes your prospective attendees eager to hear him, but still keep his identity secret and shroud him in mystery, you may want to go this route.

IDEA #40
Guess The Mystery Speaker's Identity

Those who write in the correct name of your Mystery Speaker get entered in a prize drawing.

IDEA #41
Express Delivery Of Your Information Package

I have one direct marketing client who routinely sends out 3,000 to as many as 10,000 Federal Express packages every WEEK! Yes, this kind of delivery IS expensive*, but in many instances, the impact is worth it. The arrival of a FedEx, Airborne, etc. is treated differently in most offices than just about anything else.

Last year, one seminar marketer, a client of mine, did a test: 100 packages sent FedEx, 100 by First Class Mail. Can you guess the results?

68 of the 100 FedEx recipients registered within 72 hours. Only 20 or so of the mail recipients registered quickly, and only 31 total registered. FedEx paid for itself without a question.

Always true? No. Often. Yes.

(*You can negotiate quantity discounts.)

IDEA #42
"You Have Already Won....."

These are four of the most powerful words in the entire "advertising vocabulary." These words in a pre-mail FAX or Mailgram, on the outside of an envelope, across the top of the letter are compelling.

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Let's say you have 1,000 prospective attendees. Draw 200 of them and send them the "You Have Already Won" package, that gives them a special discount, paid hotel room, cubic-Z tennis bracelet, whatever, when they register immediately.

If you want, draw 200 more out of the remaining 800 the next week. And so on.

IDEA #43
Extra-Desirable Location

Let's face it: "tax deductible vacation" does pop to mind whenever we think about attending conferences, conventions, and other events. If that can be a big draw for your group, then you have to favor Orlando (Disney World), Anaheim (Disneyland), San Diego (Sea World), Las Vegas, New Orleans, San Francisco, Phoenix, probably in that order. However, sometimes the need and desire for convenient in-and-out access supercedes this, in which case, if you're pulling from all over the country, consider Cincinnati, Kansas City or Atlanta.

In any case, be sure to "romance" your site. And you CAN romance just about ANY site. (Let's say, for example, you're going to hold your meeting in --- *Cleveland.* You need to tell about the completely revitalized, exciting nighttime entertainment complex, The Flats, right downtown, along the river, and about the Theater District, The Cleveland Playhouse, offering some of the most critically acclaimed live theater in the entire United States. The river dinner cruises. Nearby Northfield Park, with world class harness racing...where "every 7 minutes, the whole place goes crazy!" Etc.)

EVERY place has at least SOMEthing to "romance."

How To Increase The Revenue & Profits And/Or Offset Costs Of Your Conference And Of Your Speakers

IDEA #44
Pre-Event Or Post-Event Special Seminar

If you have a real "high content speaker", you may want to position him into a day-long pre- or post-event seminar, and charge an extra fee to attend. This sometimes works well if there is a speaker you had last year, who was very well received, and has a lot of content; rather than repeating him on the program, market him in a separate seminar.

IDEA #45
"Closed Door" Breakfast(s) Or Reception(s)

If you have a speaker or speakers that some people will "kill" to get with in a small group, informal setting, to "pick their brains", you may want to charge extra for such opportunities.

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IDEA #46
Share In Speakers' Educational Materials Sales

All speakers don't do this, so I can only tell you what I do. And many speakers do such a sad-sack job of offering their materials, none of this matters anyway; but in my case, it does.

I provide a confidential rebate of my at-speech educational material sales to the corporate or association client, ranging from 20% to as high as 50%, depending on the number of attendees and type of audience. This quite often winds up offsetting my fee or my fee and expenses - literally making me "free". In fact, here are just a few clients who have received from me a rebate equal to or even greater than my "cost": Ski-Doo, Floor Coverings International, Sun Securities, The Florida Insurance Association, The Excellence In Dentistry Conference.

IDEA #47
Post-Event "Joint Ventures"

One group I recently spoke for had about 500 people at their convention but nearly 1,5000 who did not attend. We did an "endorsed mailing" to those 1,500, offering my same educational materials package that they missed getting by not being at the convention, did over $26,000.00 in business from the mailing, and the client got $13,000.00 of that.

IDEA #48
OOPS! - I Almost Forgot.....

Idea #48 is one of the most powerful marketing "tricks" I know: it is: making what you are selling free (or at least "feel" free). FREE, as you probably know, has remained THE most effective word in advertising for at least four decades.

For many associations, the path to "free" lies with vendors and sponsors. If your Conference registration is, say, $500.00, what you want to assemble is (the equivalent of) a "coupon book" of discounts, rebates and gifts that is only available to attendees, that is worth more than $500.00. Getting this makes registration "free."

Depending on the size and nature of your group -- corporate or association - you can also recruit "Official Sponsors" for your convention, and require them to contribute something free, of value, as part of the sponsorship. The airline that is your "official airline" and gets most of the attendees' flights can give a Free Companion Pass to everybody. The travel agency you promote, to handle everybody's reservations, can give free garment bags. Your long-distance carrier can give everybody a PhoneCard with x-number of free long distance minutes in it. Etc. Etc.

The End.

I sure am a long-winded fellow, aren't I?

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Obviously, no one can use ALL these 48 "Big Ideas" - but I hope you found at least a couple "gems" you can use.

Thanks for your interest.

Dan S. Kennedy

PS: If you'd like to contact me, my office phone number is 602/997-7707 or FAX 602/269-3113.